Project KAZE

Sponsored and Judged by Swapna Samuel

Kaze means wind: the unseen presence that's with you reaching for help when you cannot.



Challenge statement:

How might we help people stay safe and get assistance <u>when they are no longer in a position to ask for help themselves?</u>

A person can become vulnerable unexpectedly. For example, a drink or water may be spiked, someone may become severely intoxicated, lose consciousness, or otherwise become unable to recognize danger, communicate clearly or use their phone.

In these situations, there can be a critical gap between **the moment someone becomes unable to protect themselves and the moment someone else realizes that help is needed.**

The challenge is to explore ways of closing that gap: helping a person stay connected to a trusted source of support even when they cannot make a call, send a message or consciously activate an SOS.

Solutions should prioritize **safety**, **dignity**, **privacy** and **autonomy**. Teams are not limited to a particular device, technology or delivery method. They may explore wearables, mobile

applications, environmental technologies, social systems, connected devices or entirely different approaches.

The goal is not to determine whether someone has been drugged or to predict exactly what has happened. The goal is to create a reliable way for **help to be initiated when someone may no longer be able to initiate it themselves.**

Judging criteria

- **Potential impact — 30%:** How effectively does the concept address the gap between someone becoming unable to seek help and assistance being initiated?
- **Safety and reliability — 25%:** How well does it account for missed signals, false alarms, misuse, connectivity failures and other failure scenarios?
- **Usability and accessibility — 20%:** Could the solution realistically be used in everyday social situations, including when someone is distressed or impaired?
- **Feasibility — 15%:** Are the technical and operational assumptions credible, with a realistic path toward implementation?
- **Privacy and autonomy — 10%:** Does the solution protect sensitive information while respecting the person's dignity, consent and control?

How we will judge

Teams will present their concept or prototype and demonstrate how it would respond to one or more realistic scenarios.

Will assess each submission against the weighted criteria, considering the evidence supporting the approach, its limitations and how the team would validate it.

Teams should clearly distinguish between:

- What the prototype actually demonstrates
- What is simulated
- What assumptions the concept relies upon
- What would require further testing or validation before real-world deployment.

Testing must use simulations only

Example solution direction: Connected safety system

A prototype could explore capabilities such as:

- Scheduled or event-based safety check-ins.
- Optional signals from a smartwatch or other wearable.
- A discreet mechanism for confirming that the user is safe.
- A private safety PIN to cancel an impending alert.
- A separate duress mechanism that appears to cancel an alert while silently requesting assistance.
- Automatic notification of trusted contacts when the user does not respond.
- Escalation if the first trusted contact does not acknowledge the alert.
- Location sharing with designated contacts, subject to the user's configured permissions.
- A server-side countdown so that an alert can continue even if the user's phone subsequently disconnects.

This is only one possible direction. Teams should not feel constrained to reproduce this architecture. They are encouraged to identify other ways of solving the underlying problem.

The prototype should demonstrate a mechanism for obtaining assistance when someone may be unable to seek it themselves. It should **not** claim to confirm that a drink has been spiked, diagnose incapacitation or reliably predict unconsciousness.

Example demonstration scenarios

Teams developing a connected safety solution should demonstrate how their system handles scenarios such as:

1. **Safe:** The wearer responds appropriately and confirms they are safe
2. **No response:** The wearer does not respond within the defined window and the system initiates escalation
3. **Duress:** The wearer provides a signal indicating that they need help without openly triggering an alert
4. **Connectivity failure:** The phone disconnects after an alert or countdown has been registered
5. **Unacknowledged alert:** The first trusted contact does not respond, requiring escalation to another designated contact
6. **False alarm:** The wearer or an authorized contact needs to safely resolve an accidental alert
7. **Privacy:** The system demonstrates that location and personal information are only shared according to the user's configured permissions

No real emergency calls, drug exposure or intentional incapacitation should be used during testing.

Prizes

🥇 **1st Place**: $1,500 Cash
🥈 **2nd Place**: $500 Cash